

River's end

Old rivers flow slowly in flat-lying areas, often creating muddy swamps. Eventually, rivers join the sea at a place called the mouth of a river. This is the end of the river's life. In time, the water creates new rivers, as part of the water cycle.

Floodplains are flat areas of land on either side of a river. They are created by sediment deposited by rivers over time.

Old rivers often leave wide, low ridges of sediment (tiny bits of soil and rocks) on their banks. These ridges are called levees.

Oxbow lakes are the remainders of meanders that have been cut off from a river's course.

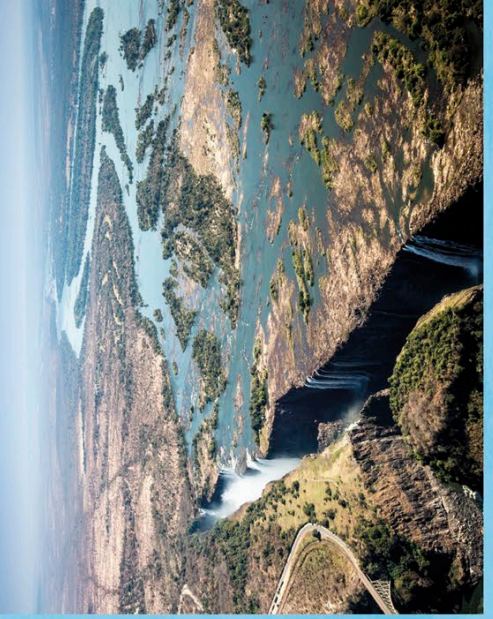
See also

Find out how rivers fit into the water cycle (32–33).

Sometimes the river splits into several branches that spread out, forming a delta. The low, flat land around a river delta is often rich and fertile.

Mississippi River delta

The Mississippi River makes a 2,350-mile (3,750 km) journey, ending in a delta, which is one of the most fertile regions on Earth. The land varies from salt marshes to sandy beaches. It is home to many endangered animals, such as the green sea turtle.



Victoria Falls With a height of 354 ft (108 m), Victoria Falls is among the largest waterfalls in the world. The local name for the waterfall is Mosi-oa-Tunya, which means “the smoke that thunders.” Found on the border between Zambia and Zimbabwe, it is fed by the Zambezi River.